"There is, however, no guarantee that public finance will reduce election expenditure or bring transparency and accountability," says former CEC N. Gopalaswami. "State funding will make no difference unless the cap on election expenditure is strictly enforced." Rawat says that state funding without any check on corporate donations and black money in elections won't cleanse the system.

In countries like Italy, Israel and Finland, which have experimented with public funding, there has been no significant drop in expenses. Only a handful of countries like Germany, Canada, Sweden and Japan have been able to reduce their poll expenditure by any significant extent. "An effective public funding model has two elements: reducing the dependency on private money by strict restrictions on expenditure limits, strong regulations and disclosures, and infusing white money through state funding or incentivising other funding options, such as tax-free donation," says Sahoo.

In India, however, there is no immediate possibility of public funding of elections, as the ECI is not in its favour. The commission has already told the Union government that it will not be able to prohibit or check candidates' expenditure over and above the state's provision, Union minister Anurag Thakur revealed in the Lok Sabha in March 2020. While the government has taken this assessment seriously, most of the ECI's suggestions in the past 25 years on introducing reforms to bring in transparency in both funding and spending in the political arena have remained unimplemented. "It may be wise for India to revisit these recommendations as a panacea for the many problems that have mushroomed with the growth of 'money power' in the electoral arena," says Chawla. Lack of political will has for long stymied the clean-up of political finance in India. The Supreme Court verdict on electoral bonds is a grim reminder that the next government has a long list of amendments to make—within the constitutional framework, of course. ■

